

# Negotiating Your Worth

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*How to Ask for More — and Actually Get  
It*

## Disclaimer

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# Why Most People Underearn

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*The wage gap between what most people earn and what they could earn is not a skill gap. It's a negotiation gap.*

## The Research on Asking

A Carnegie Mellon study found that people who consistently negotiate their salary earn \$1 million more over a 45-year career than those who don't. That's not a rounding error. That's a retirement.

And yet most people don't negotiate. Fear of rejection. Fear of seeming greedy. Fear of the offer being rescinded. Fear that the number they want is somehow unreasonable.

None of these fears are grounded in typical reality. Most employers expect negotiation. Many actually lose respect for candidates who don't negotiate — interpreting it as low self-confidence or lack of market awareness.

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*"Not asking is the most expensive thing most people do."*



# Knowing Your Number

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*You cannot negotiate well without research. Research takes 45 minutes and changes everything.*

## Salary Research Tools

Glassdoor, Levels.fyi (for tech), LinkedIn Salary, Payscale, and the Bureau of Labor Statistics Occupational Outlook Handbook all provide salary data by role, location, experience level, and industry.

Use at least three sources. Build a range: the floor (below which you won't accept), the target (what you actually want), and the stretch (what the role is worth at the high end of the market).

Factor in your specific experience, certifications, location premium or discount, industry sector, and company size. A marketing manager at a 20-person startup is paid differently than one at a Fortune 500. Research comparables, not averages.

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*"Data is confidence. Confidence is negotiating power."*

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# The Negotiation Conversation

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*Most negotiation advice focuses on tactics. The most important thing is tone.*

## Collaborative, Not Combative

The most effective salary negotiations feel like conversations between aligned parties, not adversarial standoffs. Your framing: 'I'm very excited about this role and I want to make this work. Based on my research and experience, I was expecting something closer to [number]. Is there flexibility there?'

Notice what this does: it expresses genuine enthusiasm (you're not bluffing), anchors to a researched number (not a feeling), and opens a dialogue (it's a question, not a demand).

Let silence do work. After stating your number, stop talking. The discomfort of silence is a powerful force, and most people fill it by negotiating against themselves.

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*"The negotiator who speaks next often loses."*

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# Negotiating Beyond Salary

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*Compensation is a package. Most people negotiate one item and leave the rest on the table.*

## The Full Compensation Menu

When salary has reached its ceiling, the negotiation can continue: remote work flexibility, additional vacation days, professional development budget, signing bonus, early performance review, title adjustment, equity or profit-sharing, flexible start date.

A signing bonus is often easier for companies to grant than a salary increase because it's a one-time cost that doesn't compound. Ask for it specifically if salary is immovable.

Remote work has a financial value — two fewer commuting days per week can save \$3,000-\$8,000 annually in transportation, lunches, and childcare costs. Factor this into total compensation comparisons.

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*"If the salary won't move, everything else is still negotiable."*

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# Asking for a Raise

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*The raise conversation is the negotiation most people avoid longest. It is also the most straightforward.*

## Building the Business Case

A raise request is a business case, not a personal appeal. 'I need more money' is weak. 'Here is the specific value I've created and here is the market rate for this contribution' is strong.

Document your wins: revenue generated, costs reduced, projects delivered, problems solved, teams led. Put dollar amounts where possible. Then research the market rate for your role as it has evolved (not as it was when you were hired).

Request a formal meeting — not a hallway conversation. Come with a one-page summary. Ask for a specific number. Then be quiet.

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*"A raise request is a presentation, not a prayer."*

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# Walking Away and What That Makes Possible

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*The most powerful negotiating position is genuine willingness to leave.*

## Building Your Walk-Away Power

Walk-away power is not about being cavalier about your job. It's about maintaining enough financial stability and professional optionality that staying isn't compelled by desperation.

This means: an emergency fund that buys you time, skills that translate across employers, a maintained professional network, and occasional interviews even when you're not looking. Not disloyalty — preparation.

People who genuinely can walk away often don't have to. The confidence that comes from real options changes how you show up in every negotiation, every performance review, and every interaction with leadership.

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*"Financial security is negotiating power. Build it before you need it."*

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